

COMPLIANCE CHECKLIST

Are You Ready for the UAE's Child Digital Safety Law?

Researching the Federal Decree-Law No. 26 / 2025 — Compliance Checklist & Working
Group Findings

PRESENTED BY

AI Governance & Regulation Working Group

DATE:

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01

The Law at a Glance

Federal Decree-Law No. 26 / 2025 — UAE Child Digital Safety Law

INTRODUCTION

Federal Decree-Law No. 26 / 2025

The UAE Child Digital Safety Law establishes a comprehensive framework to protect children online — regulating how digital platforms design services, handle data, and manage content.

Aligned with the UAE's '**Year of the Family**' initiative, the law reinforces safe digital environments for children and stronger caregiver involvement.

Key obligations:

- ✓ Parental consent
- ✓ Age verification
- ✓ Data protection
- ✓ Content moderation
- ✓ Child-safe platform design

Key Facts:

2025

In Force

1 Jan 2027

Compliance Deadline

Child Digital Safety Council

The Governing Body

Applicability :

- ✓ Digital platforms
- ✓ Internet Service Providers (ISPs)
(Any entity operating in or targeting users in the UAE, especially where children can access the service)
- ✓ Children's caregivers

Importance :

Compliance is critical to:

- ✓ Avoid regulatory penalties and enforcement action
- ✓ Reduce legal and reputational risk
- ✓ Build trust with users and caregivers
- ✓ Support the UAE's vision for family-focused digital safety

02

Your Guide to Using this Document

How to Navigate this checklist

This checklist is designed as a practical compliance tool to help digital service providers operationalize their obligations under the UAE Child Digital Safety Law.

It also serves as an accessible reference guide for caregivers, guardians, and anyone interested in understanding how the law protects children in digital spaces.

Rather than restating the law, it breaks down key provisions into clear, actionable steps that can be easily reviewed and understood.

Purpose:

- ✓ Translate legal obligations into practical action points
- ✓ Enable quick gap assessment and compliance tracking
- ✓ Provide a simplified overview of key protections for children online

How to Use:

- ✓ Identify obligations relevant to your platform or interest
- ✓ Review and track implemented vs. pending measures
- ✓ Use as a reference for compliance, awareness, or learning

Who This Is For:

- ✓ Digital platforms and service providers
- ✓ Legal, compliance, and policy teams
- ✓ Caregivers and guardians
- ✓ Anyone interested in child digital safety in the UAE

03

Key Platform Obligations

Articles 7–13: What digital platforms must do

FRAMEWORK

Key Obligations for Digital Platforms

Articles 7–13 — Applies to digital platforms, online service providers, and ISPs

01 Parental Consent & Data Protection

Obtain verifiable parental consent (children under 13)

- ✓ Create a separate parental consent flow
- ✓ Record timestamp + verification method
- ✓ Verify parent/guardian identity

Provide a consent withdrawal option

- ✓ Add “Withdraw Consent” in privacy/account settings
- ✓ Ensure immediate effect without penalizing the child
- ✓ Log and document all withdrawals

Disclose the privacy policy clearly

- ✓ Show plain-language privacy notice during registration
- ✓ Keep full privacy policy accessible at all times

Restrict access to child data

- ✓ Implement role-based access controls
- ✓ Apply data minimisation principles
- ✓ Maintain data access logs

Restrict use of child data

- ✓ Remove children from targeted advertising segments
- ✓ Prevent profiling of child accounts
- ✓ Audit data use to ensure purpose limitation

02 Age Verification

Implement age verification mechanisms

- ✓ Add age verification at account creation
- ✓ Use risk-appropriate verification methods (ID check, parental consent, etc.)
- ✓ Document verification method and risk assessment
- ✓ Review verification process based on platform classification

03 Commercial Game Restrictions

Restrict access to commercial games

- ✓ Block access to commercial/gambling games for child accounts
- ✓ Prevent ads for commercial games targeting children
- ✓ Prohibit use of child data for marketing such games
- ✓ Prevent children’s access through safeguards
- ✓ Implement age gates for restricted game categories
- ✓ Provide parental control blocking tools
- ✓ Apply content filters at platform/network level

Key Obligations for Digital Platforms

Articles 7–13 — Applies to digital platforms, online service providers, and ISPs

04 Child Safety by Design

Default high privacy settings

- ✓ Set child accounts to private by default
- ✓ Disable location sharing and public discovery
- ✓ Review default settings regularly

Age restriction tools

- ✓ Implement feature-level age gating
- ✓ Require verification for restricted features
- ✓ Periodically re-verify account age

Content filtering & engagement controls

- ✓ Enable age-based content filters
- ✓ Limit autoplay / infinite scroll for children
- ✓ Add content classification labels

Age-appropriate privacy & data protection

- ✓ Apply age-based data retention policies
- ✓ Restrict third-party data sharing
- ✓ Conduct child-specific DPIA

Parental control tools

- ✓ Provide parental dashboard
- ✓ Enable daily screen time limits
- ✓ Add mandatory break reminders
- ✓ Allow caregiver account management

Promote awareness of excessive use risks

- ✓ Display usage summaries or reminders
- ✓ Provide digital wellbeing resources
- ✓ Send usage reports to caregivers

Reporting harmful content

- ✓ Add easy-to-access reporting button
- ✓ Deploy AI detection for harmful content
- ✓ Establish content moderation workflows

Report harmful content to authorities

- ✓ Create direct reporting channel to UAE authorities
- ✓ Implement automated escalation workflows
- ✓ Maintain incident reporting logs

Execute removal orders

- ✓ Assign designated compliance contact
- ✓ Define internal response timelines
- ✓ Confirm removal execution to authorities

Submit compliance reports

- ✓ Track compliance metrics internally
- ✓ Prepare periodic regulatory reports
- ✓ Assign responsible compliance officer

Key Obligations for Digital Platforms

Articles 7–13 — Applies to digital platforms, online service providers, and ISPs

05 Policy Transparency

Disclose policies on user and content management

- ✓ Publish content and user policy disclosures
- ✓ Update policies periodically
- ✓ Include child-specific protections
- ✓ Notify users of policy updates

06 Caregiver Support

Enable caregiver support mechanisms

- ✓ Provide guidance tools for caregivers
- ✓ Offer accessible parental control features
- ✓ Enable caregiver reporting channels
- ✓ Publish digital safety awareness materials

04

Responsibilities for Caregivers & Guardians

Empowering the adults in the room; defining caregiver and their responsibilities

ANALYSIS

Empowering Caregivers

Child Caregiver: Any parent, guardian, or person legally entrusted with the care of a child under 18 years (Article 1).

Children under 13 receive the STRONGEST protections — explicit parental consent required before any data collection (Article 7).

Caregiver Responsibilities:

➤ **Supervision & Monitoring:**

Actively monitor children's digital activities using Parental Control Tools while respecting age-appropriate independence.

➤ **Account Management:**

Avoid age-inappropriate platforms. Prevent children from sharing accounts showing unsuitable content.

➤ **Protect Dignity & Privacy:**

Never exploit children via digital platforms in ways threatening their privacy, dignity, or psychological well-being.

➤ **Digital Literacy:**

Educate children on safe device use, risks of excessive online activity, and prevention strategies.

➤ **Reporting Obligation:**

Immediately report harmful content or child abuse material to Competent Authorities.

ANALYSIS

Platform Duties Supporting The Caregivers:

❑ **Provide Parental Control Tools**

Tools that allow caregivers to monitor, restrict, and manage a child's online activity and account settings.

❑ **Consent for Data (Under 13):**

Provide explicit, documented consent before platforms collect data — withdrawable at any time without adverse effects.

❑ **Enable Mandatory Rest & Disconnection Periods**

Features that enforce screen-time limits and ensure children take breaks from device usage.

❑ **Ensure Transparent Data Policies**

Privacy policies must be clearly explained in a way both caregivers and children can understand.

❑ **Mandate Caregiver Consent for ISP Services**

ISPs must ensure accounts are set up with verified caregiver approval and linked parental controls

❑ **Allow Easy Withdrawal of Consent**

Caregivers must be able to revoke previously given data consent quickly and without barriers.

05

Risk Classification & Enforcement

Penalty framework, regulatory tiers, and compliance triggers

KEY METRICS

Risk Classification Framework (Article 6 – pending Cabinet Decision)

In line with a risk-based regulatory approach, Platforms will be classified under a risk-based framework (Article 6 – subject to Cabinet Decision) based on:

- Nature of service (social media, gaming, messaging, etc.)
- Scale of user base
- Degree of interaction with children
- Use of AI-driven systems (recommendation, moderation, profiling)

LOW RISK

Platforms with minimal child interaction and limited data processing

MODERATE RISK

Platforms with user interaction features and content moderation systems

HIGH RISK

Platforms that:

- ✓ Process children's data
- ✓ Use AI-driven content moderation or recommendation systems
- ✓ Enable behavioural targeting or profiling
- ✓ Require age verification mechanisms

- High-risk platforms are expected to comply with stricter obligations under Articles 7, 8, 10, and 12.
- This framework aligns with international risk-based regulatory models, including the EU AI Act and OECD AI Principles .

Key Compliance Risks Triggering Enforcement:

Child Data Protection Failures

- absence of verifiable parental consent
- misuse of child data or profiling

Failure in Content Moderation

- exposure of children to harmful or illegal content
- delayed removal or reporting

Ineffective Age Verification

- weak or bypassable verification mechanisms

Non-Disclosure & Transparency Failures

Lack of Caregiver Support

- absence of parental controls or reporting tools

Enforcement Process:

1 Detection

- User complaints
- Platform self-reporting
- Regulatory audits or inspections

2 Notice of Violation

- Formal notification to the platform
- Identification of breach and applicable legal provision

3 Remediation Period

- Time-bound corrective action
- Implementation of required safeguards

4 Compliance Review

- Review and verification by the competent regulatory authority
- Assessment of corrective measures

5 Enforcement Action

Escalation of enforcement action based on severity, recurrence, and risk to children

Violation Levels (Art. 16 — Pending):

Level 1 — Minor

Delayed reporting · Minor procedural gaps

→ Warning + corrective timeline

Level 2 — Moderate

Weak age verification · Inadequate parental controls

→ Aligned with global child safety and AI governance frameworks

Level 3 — Serious

Child data misuse · Failure to remove harmful content

→ Financial penalties · Platform restriction, suspension, or service blocking (as determined by the competent authority)

06

What the World Teaches Us

UK, Australia, EU, US — global frameworks and lessons for UAE implementation

ANALYSIS

Global Child Digital Safety Frameworks:



United Kingdom

Safety by Design

- Age Appropriate Design Code — 15 standards
- Privacy by default, data minimisation
- Children's Risk Assessments by July 2025
- Dual regulator: ICO (data) + Ofcom (content)



Australia

World's First Hard Age Ban

- Under-16s banned from social media (Dec 2025)
- Compliance burden placed on platforms
- Penalties up to AUD 49.5 million
- 80% of 8–12 year olds used banned platforms anyway — showing the verification gap



European Union

Embedded in Wider Framework

- DSA recognises minors as distinct risk group
- GDPR sets higher standards for children's data
- DSA prohibits targeted ads to known child users
- Risk of patchwork enforcement across member states



United States

Fragmented but Evolving

- COPPA covers under-13s; amended June 2025
- State laws (CA, UT, NE) add verification requirements
- No unified federal framework
- Constitutional constraints slow federal action

3 Universal Lessons: ① **Legislation without verification infrastructure is circumvented** ② **Platform-first compliance works** ③ **Early regulator–industry relationships accelerate genuine compliance**

Additional considerations informed by international child rights and AI governance frameworks

Emerging Global Safeguards & Rights-Based Recommendations

Child Data & AI Systems

- Restrict or Prohibit use of children's data for training AI models
- Broaden "child data" to include voice, biometrics, usernames, and location data
- Ban biometric mass surveillance of children
- Differentiate obligations for mixed-audience and child-directed platforms

Privacy-Preserving Age Verification

- Encourage privacy-preserving "double-blind" age verification models
- Explore reusable digital age tokens to reduce unnecessary data collection

AI & Harm Prevention

- Introduce safeguards against AI chatbots encouraging self-harm
- Restrict deceptive anthropomorphic AI designs targeting children
- Include protections against technology-facilitated gender-based violence (TFGBV)

Child Rights & Accountability

- Require Child Rights Impact Assessments (CRIAs) alongside DPIAs
- Encourage independent third-party safety assessments across the AI lifecycle
- Clarify enforcement discretion/ safe harbors to support responsible innovation

Aligned with emerging international child rights principles, including the Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC).

07

Pending Decisions & Next Steps

6 awaited Cabinet decisions and actionable recommendations

ROADMAP

Awaited Cabinet Decisions

Certain aspects of the law remain subject to Cabinet decisions — platforms should prepare proactively

01 Platform Risk Classification

Classification criteria, age controls per tier, specific protections — activates Arts. 8, 10, and 12

02 Permitted Child Data Categories

Types of data collectible from under-13s; steps to obtain, verify, and record parental consent

03 Exemptions: Educational & Health Platforms

Qualifying platforms and the child safety/privacy standards they must still meet

04 Administrative Penalties

Exact fines per breach type; restriction/suspension procedures; caregiver accountability; appeals

05 Compliance Reporting & Audits

Required format, submission frequency, and how regulators will inspect platform safety tools

06 Grace Period & Regularisation

Process for non-UAE platforms targeting UAE users; any extension to the 1 January 2027 deadline

ROADMAP

Where Do We Go From Here?

Six recommended actions for digital platforms ahead of the January 2027 compliance deadline

01 Conduct Gap Assessment

Map current platform capabilities against all Articles 7, 8, 9, 10, 12, and 13. Identify priority gaps before Cabinet decisions land.

02 Assign Compliance Owner

Designate a compliance officer responsible for monitoring regulatory developments and coordinating internal teams.

03 Build Consent & Verification Infrastructure

Implement verifiable parental consent flows and age verification now — these won't change regardless of Cabinet decisions.

04 Activate Parental Controls & Reporting

Deploy parental dashboards, screen time tools, and harmful content reporting channels as baseline obligations.

05 Monitor Cabinet Decisions

Track the six pending decisions. Update compliance posture immediately upon each publication.

06 Engage with Regulators Early

International evidence shows early regulator–industry engagement leads to faster, more genuine compliance. Recommended to reach out to TDRA and UAE Cybersecurity Council proactively.

Governance & Regulation

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Thank You

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Oversight Authorities Reference:

Telecommunications & Digital Government Regulatory Authority (TDRA) · UAE Cyber Security Council · Ministry of Artificial Intelligence · Child Digital Safety Council